Keeping first-time SIP investors invested

Groww · Growth Team · SIP Retention Initiative

Business goal: raise the % of first-time mutual fund investors who still have an active SIP 12 months after starting their first one (active = at least one successful instalment in the last 30 days).

Approach: AI-powered discovery → metric decomposition → user research → problem definition → eval-gated AI MVP.

Sources: AI Discovery Engine · AI Evidence Log · Deployed MVP · User research (6 interviews)

Decomposition: 12-month SIP continuation breaks in moments of doubt

The north-star metric decomposes into seven product outcomes. The biggest leaks are B2 (active pause/stop) and B3 (passive lapse).

- **A. First-instalment success**
  Mandate registration, first debit executed, user sees units.
- **B1. Monthly debit success**
  Sufficient balance, valid mandate, retry on bank failure.
- **B2. No active pause / stop**
  User chooses not to exit when money is tight or returns look flat.
- **B3. No passive lapse**
  User doesn't forget; failed debit is caught and retried.
- **C. Expectation durability**
  Returns experience matches what was promised at onboarding.
- **D. Progress visibility**
  User sees meaning between instalments, not just flat NAV.
- **E. Re-activation after lapse**
  Lapsed users resume with minimal friction.

Discovery engine & interviews both point to B2 & B3 as the highest-leverage outcomes.

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Ingest

■ Play Store, App Store, Reddit, TradingQ&A, YouTube, Twitter. Keyword-filtered on SIP/pause/stop/return.

Theme extraction

■ Keyword first-pass + LLM confirmation. Extracts why started, what changed, pause signals, checking behaviour, outside-app actions.

Quantify

■ Theme prevalence (% of items) and cross-segment comparison (income stability, age, influence source).

Opportunity scoring

■ Impact × fixability × business alignment → ranked opportunity areas.

Output: ranked opportunity areas with prevalence %, used to pick the target segment and problem.

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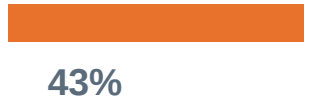
Discovery findings: pause/stop intent and flat early returns dominate

Pause / stop intent

57% prevalence. Users want to PAUSE (temporary) but the app only offers STOP (permanent).

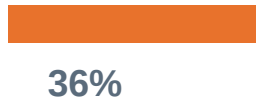
Irregular income breaks debits

Freelancers/gig workers miss monthly debits; no 'skip this month' option.



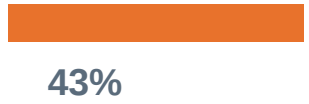
Expectation mismatch

Influencers promised 12% 'guaranteed'; first red month triggers doubt.



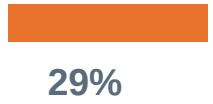
Outside-app advice

Users ask WhatsApp/family when unsure — get mixed, often wrong advice.



Silent lapse

Failed debit ends the SIP with no reminder or retry nudge.



Source: AI Discovery Engine (1,091 items). Golden-set agreement: 85% primary theme, 100% pause signal.

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User research (6 interviews): confirmed the pause gap, added silent lapse

First-time investors, age 22–30, early-career/irregular income, SIP ≤ ■1,000/month, months 3–8. No PAN/account/portfolio data collected.

Validated

Pause vs. stop gap (wanted a break, not a breakup); irregular-income debit failures; outside-app advice; expectation mismatch from YouTube.

Added

Silent lapse from insufficient funds with no nudge; daily-check anxiety driven by push notifications; 'set and forget' users never review/increase.

Quote

"I wanted a break, not a breakup." — freelancer who paused then stopped because only 'stop' existed.

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Target segment: first-time, early-career / irregular-income SIP investors

Who

Age 22–30; salaried juniors, freelancers, gig workers; first-time mutual fund investors.

Commitment

Started SIP ≤ ■1,000/month on Groww; influenced by friends or YouTube.

Moment

Months 3–8 of first SIP — first flat/negative statement or a tight month.

Why them

Highest pause/stop signal in discovery; least able to absorb a fixed monthly debit; most exposed to outside advice.

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Problem: no graceful middle option at the moment of doubt

Moment

Months 3–6: first flat/negative statement AND/OR a tight month where the fixed SIP debit is hard.

Root cause

Product forces binary choice: pay every month or stop forever. No pause/skip, no 'year 1 can be flat' context, no failed-debit retry nudge.

Workarounds

Ask WhatsApp/family (mixed advice); stop and 'restart later' (most never do); silently let it lapse.

User value

Keep the compounding clock running; avoid regret of stopping early.

Business value

Directly moves the 12-month continuation north-star metric.

Not the problem: 'investors stop SIPs when markets fall.' Continuity breaks even when markets are flat.

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Solution: SIP Pause Coach — an eval-gated AI reflection coach

Shown when a first-time investor considers pausing. The AI reflects back why they started, what's changed, and what would make this month easier — then the eval gate checks it before display.

1. User shares

Briefly say why they're thinking of pausing (no PII).

2. AI drafts

Reflective, non-advice response; no fund picks; no fear/FOMO/urgency.

3. Eval gate

Checks advice / fear / PII / relevance / disclaimer BEFORE showing.

4. Show or fallback

Pass -> AI draft is shown. Fail -> safe fallback + official Groww/SEBI links.

5. Quality dashboard

Measures output against the 20-item golden set (agreement rate).

Deployed as a public web app (https://sip-static-mvp.vercel.app). Demo mode runs fully in-browser; no API key needed. Includes an interactive discovery-engine theme detector.

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MVP tested with 3 users from the target segment

What they did

Opened the coach, shared a pause reason, saw the reflection + eval check, viewed the quality dashboard.

What worked

All 3 passed the eval gate on the first try; understood it was not advice; liked the 'pause this month' framing.

What to change

Add a concrete 'check your debit date' button; shorten the response; show the disclaimer more prominently.

Result

Users felt heard instead of pushed — a pause became a pause, not a stop.

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Success metrics, guardrails, and key risks

Leading indicators

- Pause-coach engagements per 1,000 first-time SIPs
- % of coach users who choose 'pause this month' vs. 'stop'
- 30-day re-activation rate after a coached pause

Guardrails

- Unsubstantiated fund recommendations = 0
- Fear/FOMO/urgency language = 0
- Eval pass rate ≥ 95%

Key risks & mitigation

Users ignore the coach
Place it at the pause/stop decision point in the flow.

AI drifts into advice
Hard eval gate + safe fallback; human review of low-confidence outputs.

Low adoption
Make it opt-out at the pause screen; keep it under 60 seconds.

Golden-set bias
Refresh golden set quarterly; add failure cases to the eval.

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